Akbar was not the only one under pressure as March turned to April. In Kabul, Shuja's new alliance was now under threat as his two newly co-opted allies, Aminullah Khan Logari and Nawab Zaman Khan, both began jostling for power and control over the city's resources. By mid-March their household troops had fought a pitched battle in the streets over the right to collect revenues from Customs House and the city mint.[50]

More threateningly, Shuja's credentials as a Muslim leader were now being questioned thanks to the success of Akbar Khan's overtly Islamic call to arms. 'Akbar Khan sent letters to the people of the surrounding regions,' wrote Fayz Mohammad,

> and incited them with the message, 'If the Shah is dealing honestly with the people of Islam, has no love for the English, and is discharging the duties of state and religion in your best interests, you should call for him to proclaim jihad so that united we may all attack the English and rid the country of their existence.' The Sardar kept repeating to the people the call for jihad until scholars and their students, at his instructions, placed Qur'ans kept at the tombs of saints on their heads and went among the people, village by village and hamlet by hamlet, and got prayer leaders and muezzins to begin to exhort their people to jihad. In large groups and small, people gathered at the gates of the Shah's palace and clamoured for him to proclaim a holy struggle. They cried out, 'Let us drive the English out of the country!'[51]

This put the Shah in an extremely awkward position. Publicly, he had been forced to disown his British patrons and had declared in durbar that he would work to annihilate the infidel.[52] Privately, he still felt beholden to the British and believed he needed their help to defeat the Barakzais; for this reason he sent a stream of letters to MacGregor begging him to send British troops to Kabul as soon as possible, and asking with increasing desperation when he might expect them. As Mohammad Husain Herati put it,

> His Majesty temporized, promising to send messengers to persuade the English to leave voluntarily but in reality to seek to reassure them of his continuing loyalty: first his private secretary Inayatullah Khan Bamizai, then his personal servant Din Muhammad Khan were sent. On the third occasion His Majesty wrote secretly: 'How are we to escape the pressure of these scheming dishonest Barakzais and the turbulent folk of Kabul?' MacGregor wrote back that His Majesty should hold out in Kabul for another two weeks, as reinforcements were on their way from Peshawar. His Majesty invented one excuse after another, and so hung on for a whole two months but still no help came.[53]

Given his past, Shuja's lingering pro-British sympathies were still widely suspected in Kabul, and many of the chiefs correctly believed that he was dissimulating. 'Because of his stalling,' recorded the *Siraj ul-Tawarikh*, 'the